



Serpent Mound

A giant snake-shaped mound in Ohio that continues to puzzle archaeologists

The Serpent Mound winds for 1,348 ft (411 m) along a plateau beside the Ohio Brush Creek in southern Ohio. It curves comfortably around the land, its head close to a cliff above the creek and its seven-coiled body ending in a triple-coiled tail. It lies on the now-concealed site of an ancient crater formed by the impact of a meteorite millions of years ago. It is not known if this event affected its placement or design. The earthwork was one of numerous mounds created by the Native American cultures that cultivated the fertile river valleys in Ohio. Most have been destroyed by modern agricultural practices.

The mouth of the snake

The snake is made of a layer of yellowish clay and ash reinforced with a layer of rocks and covered with soil. Its open mouth extends around the end of a 120-ft- (37-m-)

long oval hollow that might represent the snake eating an egg, although the oval could also symbolize the Sun or a frog, or merely be the remnant of a platform.

Dating difficulties

Originally thought to be the work of the Adena people, who lived between 1000 BCE and 200 BCE, the serpent was later attributed to the Fort Ancient culture from around 1070 CE, on the basis of carbon dating undertaken in 1996. However, more recent dating carried out in 2014 reallocates it to around 320 BCE, apparently reaffirming its Adena origins. The purpose of the mound remains obscure. Its head does align with the summer solstice sunset, indicating some calendrical or ceremonial function, but it is more likely that the mound had a place in funerary rites, perhaps directing spirits of the dead from nearby burial mounds.

The Serpent Mound is by far the **largest snake effigy** in the world



△ SERPENTINE LANDSCAPE

The Serpent Mound varies greatly in height, from less than 1 ft (30 cm) to more than 3 ft (1 m), and has a width of 21-26 ft (6.5-8 m).

◁ SNAKING ACROSS

While the coils of the snake effigy seem fairly uniform from above, their undulating construction makes the creature appear to slither as it winds across Ohio Brush Creek.

ASTRONOMICAL PURPOSES

There has been a lot of speculation about the purpose of the Serpent Mound. The mound does align with some important astronomical events, notably those concerning the summer and winter solstices and the two equinoxes, suggesting that these dates were of great significance to an agricultural people dependent on the production of corn to eat.

